Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on William Shakespeare's Sonnet 73

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of the speaker's effective use of metaphors in his description of his own ageing in William Shakespeare's "[That time of year thou mayst in me behold]" include

alliteration,
apostrophe,
controlling image,
couplet,
iambic pentameter,
imagery,
masculine rhyme,
metaphor,
meter,
paradox,
paragoge,
polysyndeton,
quatrain,
sigmatism,
simile,
tenor,
theme,
tone, and
vehicle.

The young literary critic should recognize that each quatrain is a metaphor whose vehicle contributes to the speaker's description of ageing. The sonnet's first quatrain focuses on images of autumn—the metaphorical declining stage of a person's individual life. The second quatrain notes the semblance of ageing and the twilight of each day. The third quatrain recognizes in the diminishing self-consuming fire that is life an extinguishing of that fire that "must expire" (line 12).

The prompt does ask the contestant to focus on the sonnet's metaphors and makes no mention of the summarizing couplet. If the young writer includes something of an explication of the thematic fourth stanza, it should be a minimal contribution to an essay whose thesis and supporting evidence focus on the metaphors that carry the sonnet's message.